

Circular Economy Transitions in the Fashion Industry: Toward Sustainable Production Systems and Resource Efficiency

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01 INTRODUCTION

The global fashion industry is among the largest contributors to environmental degradation, accounting for substantial greenhouse gas emissions, freshwater consumption, and textile waste. The prevailing linear "take-make-dispose" production model accelerates resource depletion and environmental pollution. Circular economy (CE) provides a regenerative framework that emphasizes resource efficiency, product longevity, material recovery, and waste minimization. This study explores how circular strategies can transform fashion supply chains toward sustainable production systems while identifying the key barriers and stakeholder roles influencing successful implementation.

02 OBJECTIVE

- ✓ Examine the application of circular economy principles within the fashion industry.
- ✓ Evaluate sustainable production strategies including eco-design, textile recycling, upcycling, and bio-based materials.
- ✓ Identify technological, economic, and behavioral barriers limiting circular implementation.
- ✓ Explore stakeholder collaboration for achieving resource-efficient fashion systems.
- ✓ Support Sustainable Development Goal 12 through circular production practices.

03 METHODOLOGY

This study adopts a conceptual review approach based on peer-reviewed literature, reports, and policy documents on circular economy and sustainable fashion. The literature was analyzed to identify key circular strategies, implementation barriers, and stakeholder roles. The findings were synthesized to develop a conceptual framework for promoting resource-efficient and sustainable production systems in the fashion industry.

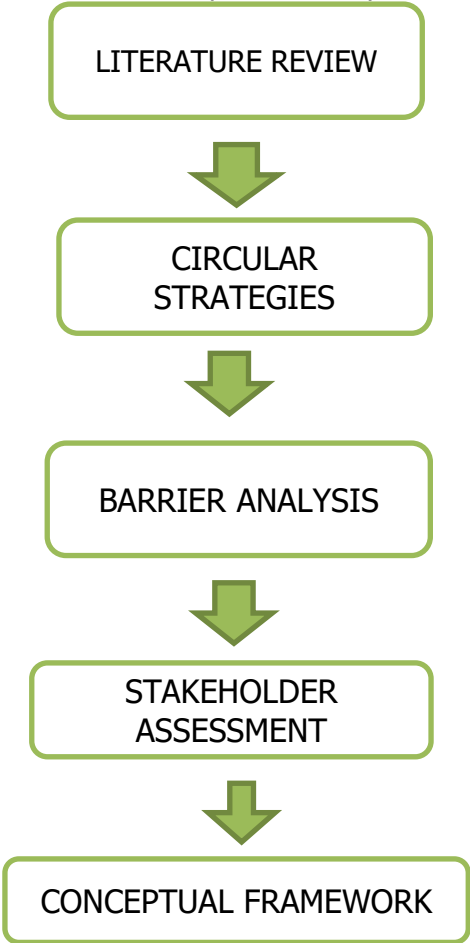
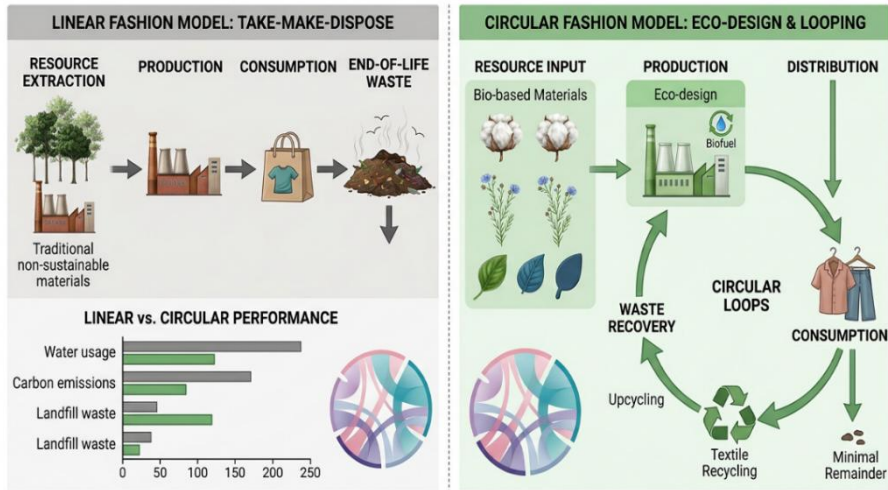


Figure 1. Schematic of the proposed methodology.

Circular Economy Transitions in the Fashion Industry



04 RESULTS

Environmental Impacts of linear fashion.

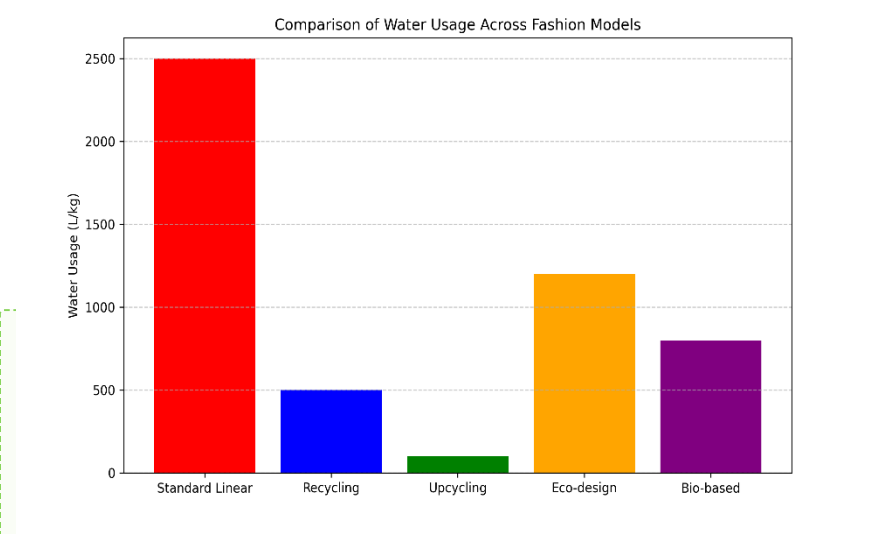
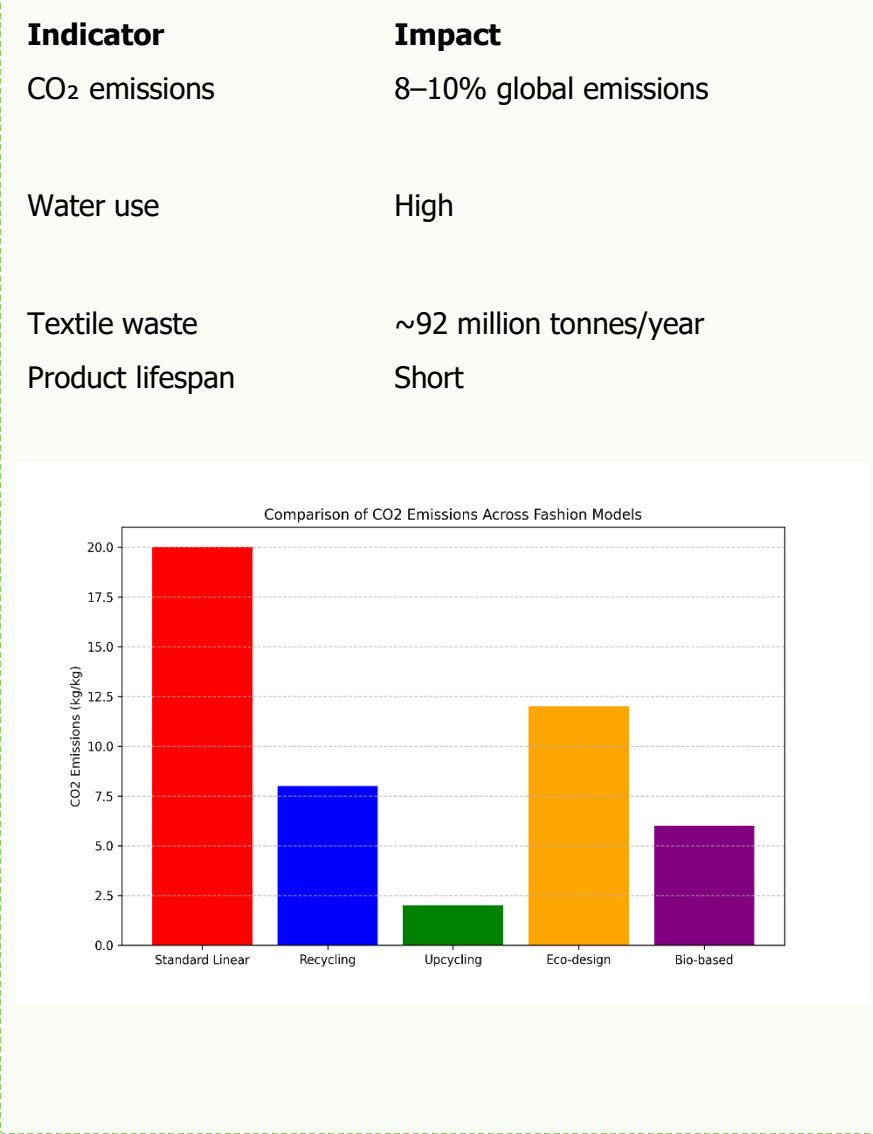


Figure 1 & 2. Illustrative comparison of CO₂ emissions and water usage across selected fashion production models. The graphs are conceptual visualizations based on trends reported in the literature and are presented for illustrative purposes only; they do not represent primary experimental data.

The illustrative comparisons indicate that circular economy strategies, particularly recycling, upcycling, eco-design, and the use of bio-based materials, have the potential to substantially reduce CO₂ emissions and water consumption compared with conventional linear production systems. Among these approaches, upcycling demonstrates the greatest potential for minimizing environmental impacts by extending material life cycles and reducing dependence on virgin resources.

05 DISCUSSION

The transition towards circular fashion requires a systemic shift from the conventional linear production model to resource-efficient and regenerative practices. While circular strategies demonstrate considerable potential for reducing environmental impacts and improving material recovery, their successful implementation depends on overcoming technological, economic, and behavioral challenges. Strengthening collaboration among industry, policymakers, researchers, and consumers, together with supportive policies and innovation, will be critical for enabling scalable and sustainable circular production systems.

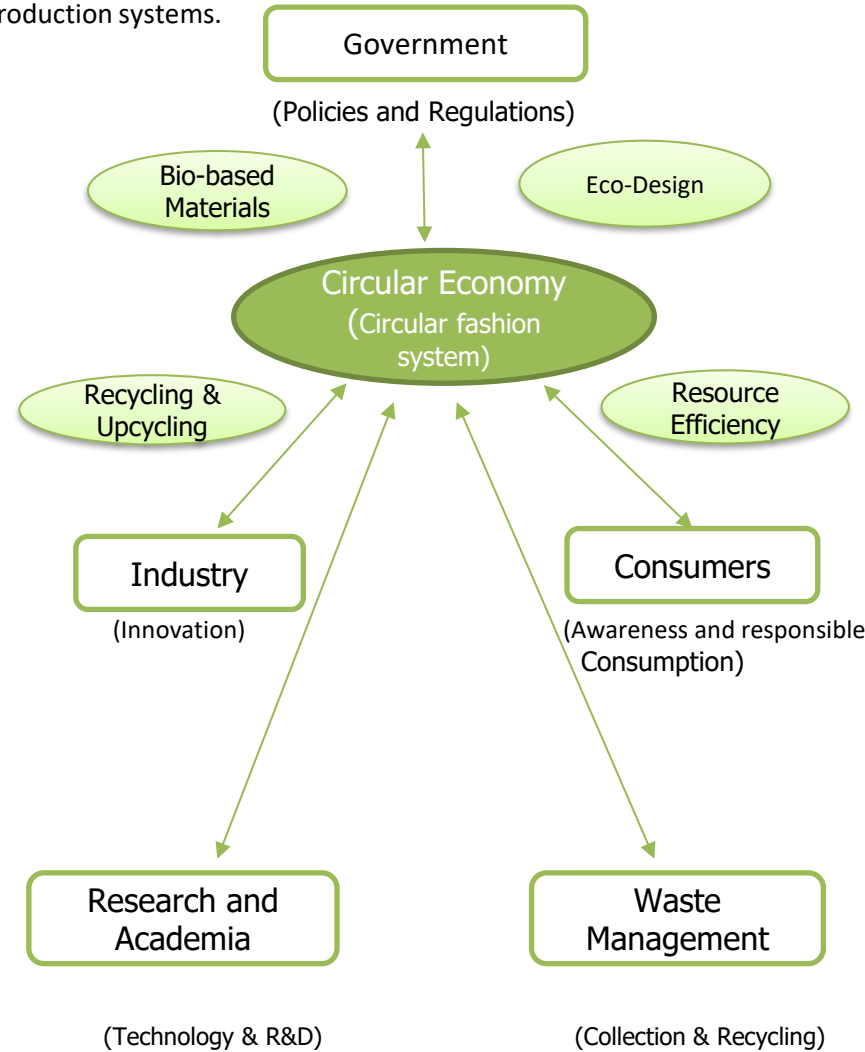


Figure 3. Conceptual framework illustrating the collaborative roles of government, industry, consumers, research institutions, and waste management systems in enabling the transition towards circular and resource-efficient fashion systems.

06 CONCLUSIONS

- Circular strategies reduce waste and improve material efficiency.
- Collaboration among stakeholders is essential for large-scale use.
- Innovation, policy support, and consumer awareness will accelerate circular transitions.

Circular economy offers a viable pathway for transforming fashion from a linear resource-intensive industry into a regenerative and resource-efficient production system.

07 FUTURE WORK

- Advanced textile recycling technologies
- Digital product passports
- AI-enabled waste sorting
- Extended producer responsibility
- Circular business models

08 REFERENCES

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09 ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The author gratefully acknowledges the organizers of SustainX 2026 for providing the opportunity to present this work.

